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Bob Stewart

Bob Stewart was born in Sioux Fall, South Dakota on February 3, 1945 and spent his childhood in New York City and Newport, Rhode Island. He has played tuba in a wide variety of contexts and has taught at the high school and college levels. Bob's recording as a leader include "First Line" (1987) and "Then and Now" (1996), where he explores the role of the tuba, past, present and future.

Bob was interviewed in Rome, New York on August 24, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Bob Stewart with me today. And I said to you a moment ago, you're my first tuba interview. We have one banjo player and now we have a tuba player.

BS: Great.

MR: Yeah. So I'm pleased to be able to talk about your career. You've, probably like most musicians, worn a lot of hats in the music business.

BS: Well it's been to my benefit to have so many hats in a certain kind of way, from Dixieland straw hat to a hat that matches with a dashiki, to you know, and all the different varieties in between.

MR: Who did you have a dashiki with?

BS: This was early in New York in the late sixties, early seventies, when the call for dress in a lot of the jazz bands during that period that weren't necessarily in the mainstream was dashiki, and this particular band was Collective Black Artists Big Band. And it was a big band that was under the auspices of Reggie Workman and people like Buster Williams and sometimes Kenny Dorham came in and sat in with the band and Frank Foster was there and Charlie Persip, drummer. And this was an organization that was the beginnings in New York of musicians sponsoring themselves. They created their own record company, Strata East and they recorded the big band and recorded other artists on the Strata East label rather than waiting for some record company to decide to bless them with the possibility of recording an album.

MR: And early on it looked like you moved around as a child? I just was reading a little bio about you and you were born in South Dakota but you didn't stay there?

BS: No I didn't stay there. My father just happened to be stationed in the Air Force. At the time my father was kind of in the Air Force as well as playing in the Negro League, the baseball league.

MR: No kidding?

BS: Yeah he was a pitcher.

MR: What years was that?

BS: He was in it through the forties, all through the forties he was in his late teens, early twenties, he played ball all through. He was an athlete and played ball all through college and played in the Negro League through the forties as well as was in the Air Force in the latter part of the forties. And my mother went out to visit him, he was in the Air Force, and they went out to visit him in Sioux Falls, South Dakota, and she was pregnant and I was born there. And so when she came out of the hospital she left and took me with her back to New York.

MR: So you lived there for maybe a day and a half.

BS: Yeah, maybe both weeks or something.

MR: You know they just honored the Negro ball league in Cooperstown.

BS: Right, just recently. In fact this is the second, it may have been more than the second but it was the second that I've heard of, coming of it. In 1991 was the first time they honored any remaining living members of the Negro League and he was inducted in the Baseball Hall of Fame in 1991 right here in Cooperstown, near here, right?

MR: Your father?

BS: My father is in the Baseball Hall of Fame.

MR: Oh that's terrific.

BS: Isn't that far out? And he was also, he had two or three interviews during the Ken Burns baseball ten episode series. It's interesting, he's in that one and I'm in the one on jazz.

MR: That's great, I'm going to look for you. Which episode is it, do you recall off hand?

BS: I don't remember off hand, like somewhere around three and four, but Reilly A. Stewart. Same initials as mine just different name.

MR: I see. Well did you have an inkling when you were nine or ten that you would be in music as a living?

BS: No. I had no idea. I had no idea. I started playing — when I was nine or ten I was still — at eight years old I was still in New York. And the reason we saw so many different cities — New York and Philadelphia and Newport, Rhode Island and then back to New York in 1968 — was because I lived with my grandparents. My father was still kind of playing ball by the early fifties and he just retired, kind of by that time the Negro League kind of phased out. And there was no hurrah at the end of it for him.

MR: Oh that's too bad. You know someone made a point, I had never thought about it, when Jackie Robinson joined the pros that that was a very important thing and good for him and all that, but it meant the death —

BS: It was the kiss of death of the Negro League for sure. I mean a lot of things happened like I don't want to get too far off the subject but if you think about integration I mean it was

a great thing while at the same time it was almost like you led people down this garden path following this carrot until you finally caught them. Because one of the byproducts of integration was they canceled the music programs and the phys ed programs in a lot of schools in the south and said they had to pay for the busing so they didn't have any music and art.

MR: I never heard that.

BS: Right. My father was in Shreveport, Louisiana and they basically canceled the music program and they were about to cancel the phys ed program and some kind of way they finagled it so they didn't. But a lot of programs got canceled like that.

MR: In the public schools because they said all right you've made us do this—

BS: Right, so now you have to pay for the busing and we'll cancel the two things that you may excel in at that time.

MR: I'll be darned.

BS: But my father moving around a lot, so I lived with my grandparents, my mother's parents, Reverend and Mrs. Simmons. And he was an AME, African Methodist Episcopal minister. And more often than not you didn't stay longer than seven years in any place. So at that time we were in New York City up at 116th and Madison at Mt. Zion AME church. It's still there as a matter of fact. And by 1953 we moved to Newport, Rhode Island.

MR: Quite a change.

BS: Quite a change. And it just happened to be the home of the Newport Jazz Festival at the time and I used to ride around Freebody Park and listen to the music on my bicycle. I couldn't find any money to get in so I would just listen. And Mahalia Jackson stayed at our house around 1958, '59 and sang at our church on Sunday morning and it was wonderful. But it was in 1956 I started playing trumpet in the elementary school, fourth or sixth grade, one or the other, and that was my first instrument.

MR: Some music teacher along the way said I need a tuba player?

BS: No. You know I played trumpet all the way through high school. I was good on trumpet. I had a scholarship to go to college, played trumpet through my first two years of college. And because of some teaching, early teaching that gave me some embouchure problems and I had to do a graduation recital in another two years, in actually a year and a half, and there was no way I would have been able to do it on trumpet so I went to a larger mouthpiece and that larger mouthpiece happened to be a tuba, and just trained new muscle rather than retraining existing muscles that had problems. And Terence Blanchard just went through this some years ago, a couple, three years ago, where he had to change his embouchure because he was having problems and it took him a while to retrain muscle. It takes, I mean to break all those habits and then come back and do it correctly,

it's very, very difficult, and I didn't have time to do it in that amount of time so I switched to tuba and did a recital on tuba in about a year and a half. I hated it.

MR: You hated it?

BS: You know what I mean? By that time I didn't realize it until I switched to tuba, I started to have, not perfect, but relative pitch. I didn't know it at the time until when I switched to tuba I found out that I could recognize all the notes on trumpet just texturally. I knew — my fingers would go down to the right place whenever the notes were played or I heard the sound, my fingers would go to the right note. And for years, I mean when I say years I mean like about ten years, I was a step away all the time playing the tuba. Because the tuba is in C and the trumpet was in B flat.

MR: Oh my God.

BS: So my fingers would go to the fingering that my ear was hearing and it would always be a step away. And I got, it was so consistent I just started to trick myself and I would make myself put a finger, wrong fingering down and get the right note.

MR: That's really interesting.

BS: And get the right note.

MR: And you were a step low? Or I'm trying to figure out how that would have worked.

BS: Well the trumpet, if I was going for a C I would go for an open note and it would be, in fact, a B flat. So I would be a step higher.

MR: Hitting the concert pitch.

BS: Exactly. I would be hitting the concert pitch and I would be a step higher than the note all the time.

MR: Wow.

BS: So it was very interesting for a while.

MR: It changes the whole harmonic scheme of the rest of the band, doesn't it?

BS: It certainly does. So I mean it took a while for me to really, my ear, those young ears, it's like young kids learn languages, they hear languages much easier than people of age. And my young ears were able to get relative pitch in those first six years that I was playing trumpet.

MR: You've played some traditional jazz along the way early on?

BS: Um hum. My first gig out of college. This was one of the things that started making me like the instrument. My first gig was on — not really first gig, my first gig on tuba was at a place called Your Father's Moustache. There was a whole chain of these things in Philadelphia and New York, St. Louis, Chicago, Joel Schiavone, his father was like this scrap metal millionaire you know. And Joel his son, with his play money I guess, established these clubs. And they did well for quite a while so they opened one in Philadelphia, so my first gig was like Monday nights in Philadelphia, I had a gig on My

Father's Moustache. And I got so good at it that they hired me this next summer, this was like '67, the summer of '67, to go down to Summer's Point and work at a club in Summer's Point. So I lived in Atlantic City and I would go to the Kentucky Club and see Jackie Wilson and all those artists, those rhythm & blues artists that were coming through then at that time, and then I would work over at Summer's Point at My Father's Moustache during that whole summer. It was a great summer.

MR: How did you learn the music?

BS: That's an interesting question. That's an excellent question. Because I don't know. But I didn't make any effort to learn the music but what happened was I used to sit by my grandmother at night and she would play the radio. And on the radio all these tunes would come on like "Bye Bye Blackbird," and "Do You Know What it Means to Miss New Orleans?" And some kind of way I knew all these tunes so when I went to Your Father's Moustache those were the tunes they were playing. And I kept feeling well why do I know these tunes? I don't know. But I knew the tunes some kind of way, so I was kind of like adapt and play the changes to the songs because I knew how the melody was about to go. That's a great question.

MR: You knew how the melody was about to go—

BS: I knew the melodies of these songs so I mean I had some idea to know kind of which way the chords were about to change to. You know? Inevitably most those songs go to a five chord or a four chord first of all.

MR: Right.

BS: And the tricky part was when it went to the relative minor then it went through the changes to get back to the major key again. But for the most part I knew a lot of these songs.

MR: That's cool.

BS: Very cool.

MR: And I was listening to, in fact I'm going to put on a little piece of something here. Let's see if I can push the right button.

[audio interlude]

MR: Now I'm not sure that we can put ourselves in the mind of that tuba player, but this was sort of new ground at the times I guess, or jazz was sort of forming. Do you know, how would that person be thinking, okay I've got to play the root then fifth?

BS: Quite often.

MR: And do you think they have — I don't even know how to phrase this question — but do would they be thinking this is two-beat music?

BS: I'm not sure whether they would be thinking two-beat music because that was the music that was being played at the time. It wasn't like there was some other music. There

wasn't a four-beat at the time. You know, so they wouldn't necessarily be thinking well am I going to go [scats] or [scats]. He'd probably just do what he was doing. He wouldn't necessarily just think of it as two-beat because at that time there was no music going [scats]. So he might not be thinking about four particularly, unless they did a stop chorus where they went [scats]. And they wouldn't necessarily think in four they'd just say it's a stop chorus of they'd do one of those [scats] or play three notes or play two notes or whatever they chose to do.

MR: Why was the — you know you said in your recent CD here that the tuba kind of went out of favor, late twenties?

BS: Late twenties and the beginnings of the swing era, beginnings when the bands started to get really larger, the big band kind of things. Still some big bands held on to a tuba player that doubled on bass like many bass players that came through that period — Slam Stewart, Major Holly, a lot of them played tuba. Major Holly was a great tuba player.

MR: You even have a picture of Pops Foster.

BS: Right, absolutely.

MR: In 1929, playing sousaphone actually.

BS: Right. Red Callender was a great tuba —

MR: Oh he did too?

BS: Yeah he was a great tuba player. Yeah. I mean he was playing with Lester Young all through most of the forties and during — you see him in movies with Louis Armstrong in the background of one of those movies where he's wearing this straw hat, you know, one of those flat brim hats. But he was a great tuba player.

MR: Was it partly volume and partly just the physical limitations of the instruments that you couldn't walk all night?

BS: I don't know. I don't really know. I was on the Spike Lee record date, it was "Jungle Fever" or it was "No More Some Blues."

MR: Oh, "Mo Better Blues."

BS: "Mo Better Blues" right. And during the record date Milt Hinton was on the date. And I asked him, I said since you were there and I know you migrated to Chicago in the late teens when you were like ten or eleven years old, why did they stop using the tuba? And his answer, coming from a person who was not a tuba player, was, "Well you know the tuba was like a country instrument. It was an instrument for parades and stuff like that. And we were moving north. We were moving up to the city. And it just wasn't hip enough. You know nobody wanted a tuba, they wanted to hear upright bass. It was like more urban and more city-fied." That's what he said. Now as a tuba player I know full well if a tuba player had to sit back there and play in one of those big bands of the thirties where in fact it was in four and you have to play to the volume of 15 cats playing horns, a

drummer, a guitar player, who quite often had, by that time they were starting to be amplified, the guitar, there's no way you could do that. I mean I started out with Arthur Blythe in his quartet, quintet. And I can't tell you how many cuts I got trying to maintain that thing without an amplifier with a contemporary drummer. And still we weren't playing as loud as one of those big bands. Trying to maintain a four feel and that contemporary style of playing, the bass function. And I mean swollen lips and ice packs and cuts and so forth. And I had, because it's just very difficult to do physically. It's very difficult to do. And to play to that volume inevitably what happens is you start getting tired. And when you start getting tired you start slowing down. You see? And that's why I know those bass players, the tuba players could not have done that, and those guys went out on the road for how many weeks at a time? There's no way his chops could have handled that. No way. So that's one of the reasons when I'm doing that function I have a microphone on my bell so when I'm playing that function I'm playing like I'm sitting in my room practicing. And so I let the — in New York, the electric company is called Con Edison, I let Con Edison do the rest of it. I let Con Edison come up to the level of that sizzle cymbal that's ringing all the time.

MR: Isn't that something?

BS: Because a drummer hits one of those sizzle cymbals — bamm — so all my notes are wiped for the next ten seconds while that sizzle — [scats].

MR: But it sure — the sound of the tuba now is indelible with sort of an era of music and it still has its place. Now you've been trying to move it —

BS: Both ways.

MR: Both ways?

BS: Because it's an interesting story. I was, for many years I took great pleasure when people would say, because I'd been working hard to try and do the bass thing and people would say, "Wow Bob, sounds great, it sounds just like a bass." I'd get all proud and just stick my chest out, you know what I mean? Because that's what I'd been trying to do, just to find the technique of how to make that role and feel like a bass player playing. And so I put a quartet together, Jon Clarke and I, a French horn player. And taped it, and it was in the early eighties when I did this, it was after I'd been working with Gil Evans. So I took the tape down to Gil Evans and let him hear it. And everyone else had been saying, "Wow, sounds great, Bob, sounds just like a bass." And Gil said to me, he used exactly the same words except he put emphasis on a different syllable. All right? He said, "Yeah, Bob, sounds great, but it just sounds like a bass." So I discovered, in all my efforts to try and sound like and reproduce that feeling of a bass I'd lost an instrument. I totally lost the tuba in my efforts. So I actively went about finding the instrument that I lost in order to, like I say, going both ways. So a lot of my compositions are influenced by New Orleans

and the feelings of that style of music. So I have, I think one of the tunes on, it's called "Hambone." And it has that New Orleans kind of feeling to it.

MR: Maybe we should just listen to the beginning of it. Because it caught my eye right away, that title for one thing and then the groove of this song which I think is very cool. [audio interlude]

MR: Is this all written out?

BS: This is Idris Muhammad playing drums. No I'm sorry, this is not Idris, he's on a previous album, this is Buddy Williams playing drums but he has an understanding about that New Orleans — he sees where he's coming from playing. That whole marching band snare drum.

MR: I can just see it going down the street. I mean I've only been to New Orleans once but I heard it.

BS: Right. But then the other part of the song is coming from a whole other place. It's not really coming, 'cause the reason I'm doing this very slow through the first time, is also coming out of the New Orleans tradition where you're going to the cemetery playing very slow and when you come back from the cemetery you're playing happy and hot you know. The second time through the song it gets faster. And that's again playing homage to the whole tradition of New Orleans while necessarily the music is not traditional but it's in the tradition.

MR: In the tradition. And then you go to this treatment. Is this a little bit of Con Edison in there with your sound?

BS: Not necessarily with the sound although I am playing through an amplifier, in most of these records I'm playing through an amplifier, because I couldn't keep this up.

MR: No I thought I heard, did you have an electronic treatment on the sound?

BS: No, not on this song, no. I don't think I have that treatment on any of these on this particular album.

MR: Maybe it's just that you're playing more sustained as opposed to oomph-oomph-oomph.

BS: Right, exactly. That's right.

MR: Well it's a very catchy, enjoyable album.

BS: Thank you. This particular tune is entitled "Tunk," T-U-N-K. And the T-U is for the tuba and the N-K is for Monk because the bass line for this tune comes from Monk's composition "Bemsha Swing."

MR: I'll be darned.

BS: It was taught to me by Don Cherry when I worked with Don Cherry. He taught me "Bemsha Swing" and this was the bass line [scats]. You know so this bass line comes from "Bemsha Swing" and what I did was just superimpose another melody on the top of it because it's a great bass line for the tuba. A lot of my things that I choose to do are bass

line kind of driven. The only one composition I've written that wasn't and that was a song for my son called "CJ" and it just — the melody came to me while watching him move around the house, where he — it's in seven and then it switches back to six. So I mean you see him walking and he's like —

MR: Is this the son that's going to Eastman?

BS: That's the one that's going to Eastman. He'll be like 20 years old — month after next.

MR: Did you find that okay you're playing an instrument that not as many people play perhaps, especially in the jazz world, so there's not as much competition on your instrument but there's not as many opportunities? Or did you make your opportunities?

BS: I think both things are probably true. And to one degree or another both things are true at whatever given time. When I first came to New York the only opportunity for tuba was at Your Father's Moustache, and soon after that, around '67, McCoy Tyner had recorded an album called "Tender Moments," all right? With Lee Morgan and James Spaulding, and just some great players. And he was doing some work with that album in New York at Slugs, it was before McCoy was of the stature to be able to go into the Vanguard and stuff, so we were doing it at Slugs over on the lower east side. And sometimes Howard Johnson, Howard Johnson was on the album on tuba and on baritone sax, he couldn't make it sometimes so he'd call me and that was my first jazz experience, in McCoy Tyner's band at the lower east side at Slugs, doing the music from "Tender Moments." Now that was one of the first jazz opportunities and after that period there weren't that many. Carla Bley was the next person because JCOA — Jazz Composers Workshop Orchestra — happened. And Carla Bley and Mike Mantler were doing things and they invited me to do tuba on some of their things. I actually sang on one of their — "Escalator Over the Hill," that, one of those early JCOA albums. And then I played on some of her other things and that's when I was in her band by the — all that led up to — all that was going on in the beginning of the seventies and by the time we got to around '76 she took that band out on the road so it was my second experience on the road. My first was with Gil Evans in '76 and then I went with her later on in the year going to Europe. But those were the two bands at that time that were kind of — so they were performing all the time so every once in a while down at the Loeb Student Center in New York where they gave their concerts — but that building's been torn down now — they would give concerts. By the mid, late seventies by '78, '79, I was doing something with Charlie Haden so it was growing by the end of the seventies. So you've got Carla Bley's band that's got a tuba book, you've got Gil Evans' band that's got a tuba book and you've got Charlie Haden's Liberation Orchestra that's got a tuba book by the beginning of the eighties, and also by the beginning of the eighties I started doing some things with Arthur Blythe, small ensemble things. So I started to mix being a tuba bass player along

with being an ensemble horn player in these big band settings. So there were two different positions that I got a chance to be in. And also because of the many hats that I've worn I was playing free jazz in Sam Rivers' Big Band that was performing and working and rehearsing at this time all through the seventies, I was playing Collective Black Artists Big Winds, which was a kind of a cultural, very ethnic — it was swing and everything but it still had a more cultural and ethnic quality to it. Then I was also working in Frank Foster's big band which was more straight ahead, Basiesque, you know.

MR: Was that The Loud Minority?

BS: Exactly that. And so I mean I was doing a bunch of these big bands and all of this was in different music. Every band I went in had different musicians. So every one of these bands had a little clique of musicians that were working the bands. So I was going between about three or four different cliques in New York, so I knew a whole bevy of musicians, all of which played different from each other. So I got a chance to see sides of New York that many trumpet players never got a chance to see because they would be in this clique but they wouldn't be hired for these other three. So I mean this was one of the interesting things and the positives of having those hats. And so I got a chance to see a lot of different music and I brought all of that, and see a lot of different bass players. With Collective Black Artists there was Reggie Workman, there was Buster Williams, and then with Frank Foster there was Earl May, and he's a very different player than either one of the first two I mentioned. And with Carla Bley there was Steve Swallow, you know what I mean? So I'm like around all these great bass players and so I'm drawing from different colors from them and how to present the bass line and therefore influencing how I try and do it on tuba.

MR: Right. Did you get the sense, when you were playing ensemble tuba, did the bass player in that group need to do any adjusting in their note choices?

BS: No. I did the adjusting.

MR: You did the adjusting.

BS: I did the adjusting because in a lot of bands, with the exception of like Carla Bley or Gil Evans, they didn't really know how to write. Early arrangements of Frank Foster with tuba in it, he wasn't writing well. He wasn't writing great tuba parts. So quite often my part was either big half note versions of the bass part or half notes paralleling the baritone saxophone. Later on he started writing differently for the tuba. I'm not sure whether I influenced that or he just started hearing it a little better, or he started understanding how to write for it and what to do, how it could fit into the ensemble better. But what I would do during the period where he was just writing me half notes, I started doing things like instead of going [scats] I'd say [scats]. I would put little chromatic things leading into the note and quite often I'd hear the bass player doing that so I would do it with him. And the

bass would look over to me and smile. So I got certain — I would take certain liberties with the music and the band leaders would never say anything. They'd say, "Oh that's cool, yeah okay," they'd just nod their head. So it allowed me to play what wasn't on the paper and get the okay from the band leader and from the bass player. So I learned how to add things, little things to the big band that weren't on the paper that helped push where the accents of things were.

MR: Probably learning that trad music in the beginning helped develop your hearing.

BS: Oh sure. For sure. Understanding exactly where that rhythm section thing was, rather than, I wasn't just an ensemble horn that didn't know the possibility was there. I was an ensemble horn that had played bass lines and things in two-beat songs.

MR: Just a technical thing — does the tuba sound an octave lower?

BS: No it sounds where you write it.

MR: It sounds where you write it.

BS: It sounds exactly where you write it.

MR: Because sometimes you see, you know a high school band or something that's short of a trombone and you'll see a tuba on the fourth trombone stand.

BS: Quite often I tried to do, when I was teaching high school at LaGuardia High School, the performing arts high school in New York, I would — we had a couple of great tuba players that came through that school and I would put them on that fourth part. And quite often the fourth part would go up high from time to time and these cats learned how to blend with the other three trombones so that they didn't miss a beat. There were some monster players.

MR: That's cool. Well would you say that you made a living as a tuba player for some time before you taught?

BS: No I taught the whole time.

MR: You taught the whole time.

BS: I mean not the whole time, there was a ten year period where I stopped teaching, but I taught, when I left Philadelphia I was teaching. Matter of fact before I left Philadelphia I taught for two years after I finished college. I finished college in '66 June and I taught from June of '66 through '67, up until June '68 in Philadelphia. And in '68 that's when I came and moved to New York. But through that whole winter of '67, September through June, I was driving to New York. I would drive, that was when I was working at My Father's Moustache. And I would drive to New York on Friday night after teaching all week and work at the Moustache Friday and Saturday. And in doing that after a couple of months I met Howard Johnson. Because he was working at My Father's Moustache, because like I said that was the only gig in town. The other gig was the Red Garter and Dave Bargeron was working at the Red Garter, the trombone player and also a tuba

player, and that was with Blood, Sweat & Tears. He was the tuba player at the Red Garter. And those were the two gigs in town where you could work steady on the tuba. And so I would come in and do the weekend, I met Howard, we would hang out and I started learning how to improvise and stuff and we would, after he finished the gig at 3:30 I would finish at 3:30, and we would meet up at Warren Smith's loft up on 21st Street and we would hang out and play until four, five, six in the morning and go to sleep and then get up and go have breakfast on the lower east side, you know what I mean? It was a great winter. I learned a bunch. And so I would, by the end of the winter, by say February, he formed the group Gravity.

MR: That is a great name by the way. It's perfect.

BS: He formed the group Gravity and so not only was I coming in on Friday but I would drive in on Thursday. I wanted to play, you understand? So I would drive that hundred miles from Philadelphia into New York, do a rehearsal after teaching all day on Thursday, get back in my car, drive back to Philadelphia, teach on Friday, get back in my car, drive back to New York and do the weekend in New York. I'm very lucky to be here, I'm telling you, because lots of times I would wake up in a different lane. Yeah. I'm very lucky to be here I'm telling you. I'm going to have to thank somebody because I'm very, very lucky to be here because I mean there's lots of times I fell asleep when I was driving.

MR: I can imagine after, especially the drive on Friday after the Thursday drive and the Friday teaching.

BS: Right. Friday was the rough one.

MR: I'll bet.

BS: Friday was really the rough one. But I did that for like four or five months from January through June and then by July of '68 I said I'm gone. And I quit my job in Philadelphia and came to New York.

MR: Did you have a family at that time?

BS: No I was just married. I was married but I didn't have any kids. And I moved to New York and I got a job teaching in New York and I was playing at My Father's Moustache and doing that, and kept it all going. I would go to rehearsals and that's when I started going to rehearsals with Sam Rivers, going to rehearsals with Collective Black Artists, so I'd go to two or three rehearsals every week because I was doing the teaching thing that I was doing. So like I said I wanted to play.

MR: In the Your Father's Moustache band, was that sort of a typical banjo?

BS: Um hum, two.

MR: Two banjos.

BS: Plectrum and tenor — loud as hell. Lord have mercy, loud as hell. And they had a microphone and they were singing, and they had a trombone player that was even louder than that and a guy named Joe Terra who dressed up in a clown's outfit playing washboard. He was really good [scats]. He swung, actually. I mean he was killing. And they even had another guy that worked for NBC sports and he would play washboard with laying it on his lap but he would do it with knives. [scats] I mean these guys really did swing actually, they were great. And that's what I would do Friday night and Saturday night from 8:30 to 3:30 in the morning.

MR: Oh my God.

BS: Do you understand? And a swollen lip later. Cuts, you know what I mean? They all had microphones and I was blowing a bossa nova all night long. So like I said that's the gig I cut my teeth on so everything after that was a piece of cake. I never complained about a two or three hour gig after — so what, it ain't nothing. I used to work six hours.

MR: Get me, I'm superman.

BS: You know what I mean? Really. But the gig actually taught me how, people get amazed with my endurance now when I'm playing, standing up there playing tuba bass for an hour at a time, and they say like, "How do you do that?" I mean that's how I did it because I learned doing six hours. And I learned how to pace myself, I learned how to blow and relax. Because what kills you when you don't relax. If you don't relax you'll get tired. The tension, you'll get tired, when you get tired you slow down, you slow down the whole process you know, because you're finished. So I had to learn how to relax and do that job.

MR: Wow. I noticed you play a four valver?

BS: Um hum.

MR: How does that make a difference?

BS: Well that fourth valve, there are some flugelhorns that are made with four valves — Miraphone, the tuba manufacturer makes a flugelhorn, and there are probably some other manufacturers. Jimmy Owens plays a flugelhorn with four valves and there are a couple of other people. I think Earl Gardner, no maybe not Earl Gardner, somebody else plays the four valve, but Jimmy Owens definitely does. What it does is like on trumpet the lowest note is F sharp, all three valves down. And then if you've got good chops you kind of play a pedal — I'm talking the trumpet pitch now — a pedal C. But with that fourth valve it allows you to play all the notes between that low F sharp and the C in tune. So F sharp, low F would be one and four, the low E would be the one, two and four or two three and four, low E flat is one, three and four, low D is all four down, and then you get the pedal C. But you can play them all, they're all built on the horn with that fourth valve.

It also is a substitute for one and three. Anything you can play one and three you can play with the fourth valve.

MR: I see. You spent some time with — well you've got a long, very interesting list of associates. Talk about Charles Mingus a little bit.

BS: Sure. Sure. I got that gig in '71, 1971. He put together, I think it was some anniversary of the big bands so he put the band back together in 1971. "71? '72? '71 he put the band back together. Because I had just come off the road, that was the January I quit teaching, January of '72 I quit teaching because I went out on the road with Taj Mahal. That's when that happened. And we were doing Taj Mahal, the blues singer, he had this rock & roll blues band with four tubas in it and all of us doubled, that's when the first time I played flugelhorn again, trumpet again, since I left it in college, I started playing again. I had forgot all the bad things and I could play it actually. It was great.

MR: Oh isn't that interesting.

BS: That time passed, I forgot how to do it wrong, and so when I picked it up I was doing it right, it worked. And Howard was doubling on flugelhorn and baritone saxophone and Joe Daly was tuba and valve trombone and Earl McIntyre was tuba and bass trombone. So we did that for the first four months of 1971, it was '71. And then when that finished in April I was kind of like depressed because I mean it's hard coming off one of those gigs where you're playing for 5,000 people and 10,000 people, screaming and hollering, you know what I mean, you're traveling posh, you know what I mean? You're being escorted here and escorted there. Then all of a sudden there's nothing. You know what I mean? So I'm sitting around patting my foot and looking at my watch and Howard Johnson calls me up and he says, "Mingus is putting a band together, he wants to use tuba and baritone man, come on down to such and so and so." I said, "Yeah, cool." And so they put the big band together and we did two albums. One was a live album at Avery Fisher featuring it was like Bill Cosby was the host and people like Gerry Mulligan and Gene Ammons was on the gig and he was just back to be able to play because he got his green card again. And there was a bunch of artists on there, I can't even think of all of them right now, but it was an amazing gig. And then he did another studio album for Columbia called "Let My Children Hear Music" and there was a written solo with me and French horn, a duet on "Don't Be Afraid, the Clown's Afraid Too" which is great. So I got friendly with Mingus and one incident happened in the band where I had to break up a fight and Mingus was just floored by that, he said, "Did you see that man, did you see what he did?" I just picked up a cat and took him out of the room into the next room, and Mingus just loved that. He didn't even try to stop the fight, he wanted to see how it was going to go and then I separated the cat and took him in the room, so Mingus hired me to

hire the band for that Avery Fisher Hall concert. And he was great to me, he was just as nice as he could be.

MR: Yeah because people talk about how volatile he could be.

BS: He was. He was just nice to me because he saw me do that so he figured I wasn't one of the people he should be messing with. So he said well if he can do that, sure, he can control my band, so he hired me to do his straw boss, to hire cats for the next gig.

MR: I'll be darned. It could be the first time in history a straw boss played the tuba.

BS: Right. I'm sure. I'm sure. But he was cool. I mean I heard little stories and everything about Bobby Jones and all the different cats that suffered under his hand, I watched him fire cats and before they could walk out the back door he hired them again. "Where you going? Bring your ass back here." But he was great.

MR: Eddie Bert was on that group?

BS: Eddie Bert was on that gig. I just saw him recently. He comes and sits in — I'm teaching at Lehman College and he comes down and sits in with the band sometimes. Yeah Eddie Bert was on that gig.

MR: You know it's funny about Eddie, I'll bet you he'll be able to tell you how many miles it is between his house and this Lehman College. Ask him about that.

BS: Oh yeah, oh yeah, no, that was one of his complaints. That's why he stopped coming because, you know, it's an hour between my house and here, and it's an hour back and he's glued to his watch, and I said yeah, okay.

MR: I just remember about that, he told me what he's doing now and every gig he mentioned he had the mileage memorized or something. Interesting.

BS: Right.

MR: So you've gone from music that has a long history of a tradition and stuff that's pretty groundbreaking too. Is that fair to say?

BS: Which part was groundbreaking?

MR: Lester Bowie?

BS: Oh yeah sure. Well he, again, because he had heard me play with Arthur Blythe and so he invited me to be a part of Brass Fantasy, and so I got to be the bass player in that group of all brass players. Again, homage and tribute to New Orleans while again taking the music and trying to go to the next mile while using traditional instrumentation, you just are paying homage to the tradition and not necessarily being traditional. You know? And he took it to a whole bunch of other different places.

MR: When I was listening to — the one I have is called "Avante Pop."

BS: Right.

MR: And as I was listening to it, sometimes you're trying to figure out what is the intention of this record. And sometimes I almost felt like he was trying to get airplay on an easy

listening station — or maybe not easy listening but he's doing "Saving All My Love for You" but then on the other side of the record there's this thing called "No Shit."

BS: Right.

MR: And so okay, now where's he going with this.

BS: Well I think, I would have conversations with him and I had conversations with Carla Bley about the same thing. I mean I listen to the jazz stations in New York, I hardly ever hear him play Carla Bley's music. And she would complain, she'd say, "My stuff is really easy to listen to it's just like this and this and this. I don't understand what problem they have with it. Why don't they play my music?" She would always get voted on in the polls and *Down Beat* things but very seldom would they play her music on the radio. And Lester felt some of that same frustration where he thought his music, even though he may have been known like Art Ensemble of Chicago which was kind of on the border and leaning on the music a little bit. A lot of the things we did with Brass Fantasy were really very palatable. And so he was trying to get some airplay. He wasn't necessarily going all the way overboard because a lot of the arrangements, when we did them live, they would transcend "Saving All My Love" and become this whole other thing. Like we did one of Billie Holiday's, "Strange Fruit" and it's very emotional, very, very emotional. I mean even to the point of we were in Europe and we were on tour once and he bought a starter pistol and so when we got to the hanging part and the band kind of plays free for a period and he pulls out a starter — bang-bang-bang-bang-bang. People bailed out ducking or hitting the ground, it was hilarious. "Oh what are they doing, what are they doing?" You know what I mean? And then they would go back into the tune again and it's like, but we did a bunch of stuff like that where he really does take "Saving All My Love" and lean on it. You know? Really lean on it. Or a lot of the tunes, Biggy Smalls' tune and just lean on it and do stuff with it in terms of improvisation. Just like when he was asked to do the theme for the "Bill Cosby Show." What he plays, he's not trying to get airplay. You see what he's playing is really abstract, but it works.

MR: You know I didn't even know that was him.

BS: That's him.

MR: Now I've got to listen to it again.

BS: That's Lester Bowie playing that very [scats]. That's him. As a matter of fact I listened to some of the things that Wynton's doing now, more recently, and he's doing Lester. I mean a lot of the things, as much as he may have objected at one point or another to Lester, the thing is when he's doing a lot of his half-valve thing, he does a whole piece of half-valve, that's Lester. There's no other trumpet player that played like that. You know? So a lot of things that he's doing, whether he wants to admit it or not, are admittedly coming out of Lester Bowie.

MR: Are you still — you said you retired from teaching just recently?

BS: I retired from the Board of Education in New York. You know I did 25 years so I retired from that, but I'm still teaching and I run the jazz program up at Lehman College as well as I teach jazz history at Juilliard, one semester a year, which is plenty, it's enough. And it leaves me time to practice, tour, or do whatever I need to do.

MR: Yeah. Is it hard to teach the history of jazz in one semester?

BS: Yes.

MR: Time, I mean like to give credit due.

BS: Yes, very difficult. Because most of the time, even if you teach from 1900 to 1950 in one semester it's difficult because you spend most of my time figuring out who to leave out. You know what I mean? Just who do I — because you can't tell them about it because there's no way they're going to remember if I start laying all the names on them and everything. So I try and pick key people so that they remember, you know but I also put out a disclaimer when I say listen, now when you go to your friends or your friend who's a jazz fan and you say well I learned about this and this and this, and they say to you well what about such and so and such? And you say well he didn't tell us about him. I said I'm telling you now, that's going to happen. Because there's no way I can tell you about everybody and hope that you will remember anybody. So I'm trying to tell you about certain people and deal with that rather than give too many names to you and you don't remember anything.

MR: What do you think jazz education has done for the music as far as — we've got lots of places to go now to study and to be a jazz musician. Has it changed the way the music is developing do you think?

BS: I'm sure it has. It's kind of like what we spoke about earlier, an integration, and Jackie Robinson getting into the pro leagues.

MR: Oh yeah.

BS: It has its pros and cons. I mean he got into the pro leagues but it meant the death of the Negro League. There are a lot of schools that have jazz programs and they graduate these students who have never really played with anybody and so therefore a lot of their information has come from somebody who has never played with anybody.

MR: It's a circle.

BS: Exactly. So they're getting second hand information and then the school hires them to teach. And so now they're giving third hand information, none of which they know first hand. And that's, I mean it's great that jazz is being taught, you know what I mean? People will ask me the question well what do you think about what Wynton's doing down at Jazz at Lincoln Center. What do you think about what he's doing? Or they'll ask me about the Ken Burns Jazz, say what do you think about that. And I'll say well you

know it's better than the last one they put out. And they'll say well which was the last one they put out? I'll say there wasn't none.

MR: Would you rather that they didn't do it?

BS: Right, exactly.

MR: Or that there wasn't a Jazz at Lincoln Center?

BS: Exactly. I say there wasn't none. I say that's the one it's better than.

MR: Yeah. I have to remember that.

BS: Okay. And they'll say well what was the other one, I'm trying to remember, what was the other one? And I'll say it wasn't none. So it's definitely better than what was going on before. It has to start somewhere.

MR: Well those jazz teachers/professors who haven't done the gigs and all that, I think they don't know how to teach a student how to play a gig. That's part of it for me. That has to be — you can play all these things you've learned but how do you play a gig?

BS: How to play a gig or how to keep a gig.

MR: Yeah.

BS: You know how to do I play to keep a gig? You know what I mean? Because you may play a gig and get fired right afterwards, but how do I play — I mean I had to learn that, there's a bunch of work that I've done that — it was Howard Johnson's gig before I played it. And I'm not saying, I don't play — I don't even begin to play what I think of as better than Howard Johnson by any stretch of anybody's imagination because Howard Johnson is this genius musician. And I'm not just saying tuba player. He's this genius musician that arranges, he plays anything he picks up, electric bass, tuba, baritone saxophone, pennywhistle, you know what I mean? But when I play for someone I play for them what they would ask me to play if they could think of it. So therefore everything I play — oh yeah, Bob, yeah that's great, leave that in. So they trust me. And so I can apply myself to them, very personally think about what it is they want in this band and not just bring my politic to their band. And I definitely have a politic but I don't — I bring it, but I temper it with what they need in their band. And quite often, more often than not, they never tell me not to play extra things I might put. Just like when I started playing with a bass player [scats] it grew from that. And so Carla Bley would hire me and Howard said, "Man I'm not sending you in to sub anymore, you keep taking my damn gigs man." But that's my, I kind of become these people. And that may have also to do with earlier we spoke about the hats you know, where I understand those different genres of music so I can apply myself to them in a certain way that they appreciate. Because Frank Foster didn't have a really great appreciation for the free players particularly, but I could work with him and the free players. You know, I worked with Globe Unity which was a European free playing band and I understood how to do that. So I mean I don't

really see a big difference between Dixieland and playing free improv. I really don't. Because I do both and I know both require big ears. You have to listen. You have to listen. And what you then do is you're either playing inside a tonality or you're playing outside of any tonality. But what you play has to do with what's going on. You see what I mean? And those rules apply to both of those musics. So it's about listening.

MR: If you're playing in a free situation and you're, especially if there's no bass player, do you feel the — I don't know if responsibility is the right word —

BS: Taking time, playing time or something?

MR: Time, yeah but you also could direct things harmonically if you wanted to it seems like.

BS: Time is a fleeting thing. And it is a thing that it's fleeting as well as it's there whether you play it or not, you know what I mean? If I say [scats] [pauses] you still hear it, don't you?

MR: It's still there, yeah.

BS: And I wait and do some other thing [scats] [pause] there it is. You see what I mean? It stays in the air. So you don't have to keep playing it for it to be there. In between those things I can say hit a note and do a multiphonic [scats]. That's time. In a free situation that's time. It's that time. It may be shorter or longer, each one of those phrases, but that's time, you see what I mean?

MR: Yeah. It's a sort of a different way of codifying it, it might not have been four bars later that you decided to come in with that.

BS: But that's what I mean, you apply yourself to the situation and so therefore what the definition, how you define time, is different than how you define time in a twelve bar blues. This might be longer or shorter than a twelve bar blues, depending on where you start on it, but it's still time. It is that time. I just heard Charles Tollver's big band. And he does this thing, a phrase, it's a phrase. But in that phrase he has elements. He has the saxophones going [scats] and he has the trumpets going [scats] and he has the trombones going [scats]. There is no ding-ding-ding — there is no time. But that is the time. And when that phrase happens that's the phrase. Once they've played that and they start getting into the rhythm of playing those things, those elements, none of which necessarily relate tempo-wise to each other, but they still are the phrase. And from one time to another something may speed up or slow down but that is still the phrase and that's a different concept of time. I mean after he'd played it once, I said oh, and I could feel the time, the rhythm of time of those phrases between each other rather than this phrase has some relation to the time and that phrase, it's the relation of just them counterpointing each other that becomes the time you know. And so it varies according to the situation so that again, like I said, I don't have a politic — a lot of cats have politic in music about the thirteen note, the twelve notes, and how/what order they go in you know what I mean? I got my first experience with that in college when they wouldn't let us practice jazz in the

practice rooms you know? I said but these are the same notes I play when I do the Haydn Trumpet Concerto, why can't I play like a bebop, so what's the difference? "You can't play that in the practice room, you have to get out of the practice room if you're going to play that."

MR: That was sixty —

BS: That was '62 to '66, the Philadelphia Musical Academy. Now it's an all-jazz school.

MR: Right.

BS: It is. It's the School of the Arts or something like that and basically it's all improvisation, whether it's folk music or whatever, it's an all-improvisational school now.

MR: I have to share a little — Don Menza said the same thing. He was at Fredonia. SUNY Fredonia. He said playing Dixieland was misdemeanor and playing bebop was a felony.

BS: Oh yeah right, okay. Right.

MR: Any new hats you're going to be wearing in the near future?

BS: Yeah I've got a great hat, that I mean it's an old hat but it's new to me. It is the Classic Jazz Trio.

MR: The Classic Jazz Trio, with tuba?

BS: Except with tuba. Tuba bass, piano and drums.

MR: Tuba, piano and drums.

BS: I have the Classic Jazz Trio except it's been bass, drums and piano, coming out from Oscar Peterson to Tatum to Ahmad Jamal. It's got influences of a lot of that but it's just with the tuba. Billy Hart's playing drums. We did a gig recently and we got reviews from the *Times* and the *Voice* and everything, it was really fantastic. And we're going to be doing something else up at Columbia come, if you're available come on into the city, please. The 31st is going to be a party. Columbia has this annual Halloween party. Dr. Robert O'Meally up at Columbia School of Jazz Studies.

MR: I've met him, yes.

BS: Where he's doing comparison things between jazz and the improvisational approach of jazz and the improvisational approach of jazz writing and people like Richard Wright and Zora Neale Hurston and people like that, how they have an improvisational approach to their writing skills. And he does a lot of that. And he also presents jazz things, he has a whole jazz program through the course of the year and he's asked me to perform for his Halloween party. Last year they did that it was Sun Ra. Right. It was Sun Ra's band that is. And so I feel real honored. It's going to be a great time.

MR: Cool.

BS: It's going to be a great time. We're going to be doing music from Simone to my compositions to Second Line, you know, again reaching forward and reaching back so the techniques that I need to play a Simone type tune or a Charles Tollver "Ruthie's

Heart" type tune, and also the techniques going backwards and playing a second line type presentation.

MR: Just so I have another sort of definition, second line, can you tell a student who might be watching this, what does he mean by that?

BS: Second line? The literal translation is literally the second line, and the second line of musicians in most bands is the drum line, the drum line, the tuba, bass drum, snare drums, cymbals. It's the second line. And on stage it's the second line. When a sound guy talks about, "Yeah I'll bring in the second line today," he's bringing in the amplifiers, the drum kit, and so forth and so on, which is the reason I name one of my bands the First Line Band, it's just a play off of, I'm putting myself in the first line, thank you very much. So we call it Bob Stewart's First Line Band. But it's physically the second line. And then the techniques that are used by that second line in New Orleans gives the name of the music they play Second Line Music. It transcends the literal term to a kind of a more active term, Second Line Music.

MR: A kind of groove?

BS: It's a way of playing the groove, playing second line with that accent on four and it's coming off the tango. In the Latin music it's the clave but they don't end up playing the clave. I recently have taken a turn about the clave, I don't want to digress or anything, but the music of Benin in Africa.

MR: Benin?

BS: In Africa, right, B-E-N-I-N. They have a whole brass tradition in Benin. And part of that brass tradition is the origins of the clave because the music they play is [claps] and they didn't get it from Latin America.

MR: No.

BS: No. It comes from there and the tuba is the bass and the tuba — I went to a concert this brass band Gangbe — G-A-N-G-B-E — Gangbe, a brass band coming from Benin. And it was at Carnegie Hall after hours. And I got there a little late and I heard music coming out of the sound system coming down the escalator and I said why are they playing this Latin band on the Muzak while the band is on stage playing because the bass is going [scats]. I said why are they playing Latin music, and then going [claps rhythm]. And when I went in there it was this band playing and I got this huge Aha. Ahaaaa. They talk about the clave and it's played in Latin music and everything but all that came from —

MR: I'll be darned.

BS: And I was reading a book about slavery and where people landed. And in the book it spoke about people from Benin landing all through the Caribbean. All through like down around Cuba and all those islands all through there and down in like the northern part of down in — the people from Holland and the music of Guiana, Dutch Guiana landing

there, which also has a tradition that parallels in so many ways I mean it's unbelievable, it parallels the whole Dirty Dozen Brass Band type tradition. They have the snare drum separate, they have a bass drum separate, the tuba is the bass, the ensemble looks like the Dirty Dozen but the music that comes out is night and day different. That's one of the tunes that I recorded called "Sugar Finger." It comes from Dutch Guiana, it's a traditional song from Dutch Guiana.

MR: Oh that's really fascinating.

BS: And again they get their instruments from orphanages, from being in the Army band, then they take the instruments and play the traditional music with it. I mean it really parallels New Orleans except it's about a thousand miles away down in the northern coast of South America.

MR: Wow.

BS: Right. I'm thinking very seriously about if I do a doctorate to do it based off of the tuba coming out of all these traditions and how slavery, you know, I did a piece once on a talk at Jazz at Lincoln Center about marching band, what's it called when countries go into another country and they take the — colonization.

MR: Colonization, um hum.

BS: Marching band colonization in jazz.

MR: Wow.

BS: You know what I mean? And how colonization, all those European countries that colonized brought their marching band to those countries, whether it's India, whether it's the Philippines, whether it's down in Guiana, whether it's the United States. And then we took those marching band instruments and played what our folk, what we consider to be our traditional folk music with it, all those different countries. So you've got brass band traditions all around the world.

MR: That's really fascinating.

BS: And the only one that evolved into jazz was into the United States. Check it out. I mean it's pretty amazing. It's pretty amazing if you think about it. It sounds like massive work to do. I don't have time.

MR: You get two Ph.Ds for that.

BS: I'm telling you man, I'm telling you.

MR: Well this has been really fascinating for me, I've learned a lot just sitting talking to you.

BS: I appreciate your knowledge and great questions that you asked.

MR: Thank you. So I wish you the best of luck with all your hats and I hope your son does well at Eastman. What's his instrument?

BS: He plays violin. He plays violin. He plays classical violin but he's also, he's got great ears and he's a great jazz player.

MR: Excellent.

BS: Yeah he's going to be something.

MR: Well he's going to a good spot.

BS: Yup indeed. Thank you very much for the invitation.

MR: My pleasure.

BS: My pleasure, my pleasure. Hope it goes well. Good luck with your project.